Ecocriticism

An Introduction

What is Ecocriticism?

- "Ecocriticism analyzes the role that the natural environment plays in the imagination of a cultural community at a particular historical moment" (Shoba).
- Ecocriticism is a type of "Environmental Literary Studies" based on a feminist ethics of care, postcolonial theory and, **today**, a focus on climate solutions, unnecessary suffering, and social equity.
- Ecocriticism begins in the early 1990s. Its roots are in Deep Ecology & Social Ecology.
- Ecocriticism explores how nature is used literally or metaphorically in verbal, visual or other arts.
- "Ecocriticism is by nature, transnational, multicultural, interdisciplinary, and pluriform" (Oppermann).

Ecocriticism Begins with Deep Ecology

- A reverence for nature as an intrinsic, autonomous good; equal rights of non-human species.
- Observation of natural landscapes, elements, or events, *nature writing,* that may feature an identification between a human speaker and entities or animals of the natural world.
- Earth stewardship or interbeing as alternatives to rapid industrialization and commercialism.
- Examples: indigenous and communitarian ways of knowing/being; Rachel Carson, *The Sea Around Us*; William Wordsworth, "Tintern Abbey," Henry David Thoreau, *Walden*, Annie Dillard, "Living Like Weasels;" Gary Snyder, "Rip Rap."

Language frames knowledge

Tiokasin Ghosthorse (Cheyenne River Lakota Nation of South Dakota) explains that the closest Lakota word to the English language *water* is *mni* which represents this substance in verb form as energy, action, force. There are no such terms as our *water* (noun, thing, object, commodity.....), for all is in a state of *active being or becoming*.

Dinner at Apelles

He set before his dinner guests a meadow, sacrificed,

as if he meant to feed, instead of his neighbors, goats,

with heaps of dandelions, chicory, asparagus, rue,

leek, green onions, mint, arugula half gone to seed,

and who knew what. I grazed at first on lupine sprouts,

but thinking that the next course might be hay, I left.

Ammianus Marcellinus (Greek) c. 400)

Pastoral Poetry of William Wordsworth

These waters, rolling from their mountain-springs
With a soft inland murmur.—Once again
Do I behold these steep and lofty cliffs,
That on a wild secluded scene impress
Thoughts of more deep seclusion; and connect
The landscape with the quiet of the sky.
The day is come when I again repose
Here, under this dark sycamore, and view
These plots of cottage-ground, these orchard-tufts,
Which at this season, with their unripe fruits,
Are clad in one green hue, and lose themselves
'Mid groves and copses.

"Tintern Abbey" (1798)

Gary Snyder, "Rip Rap"

Lay down these words
Before your mind like rocks.
placed solid, by hands

In choice of place, set
Before the body of the mind
in space and time:
Solidity of bark, leaf, or wall
riprap of things:
Cobble of milky way,
straying planets....

Annie Dillard, Living Like Weasels

Weasel! I'd never seen one wild before. He was ten inches long, thin as a curve, a muscled ribbon, brown as fruitwood, soft-furred, alert. His face was fierce, small and pointed as a lizard's; he would have made a good arrowhead. There was just a dot of chin, maybe two brown hairs' worth, and then the pure white fur began that spread down his underside. He had two black eyes I didn't see, any more than you see a window.... Our eyes locked, and someone threw away the key (13-14).

Social Ecology (early 1980s) asks...

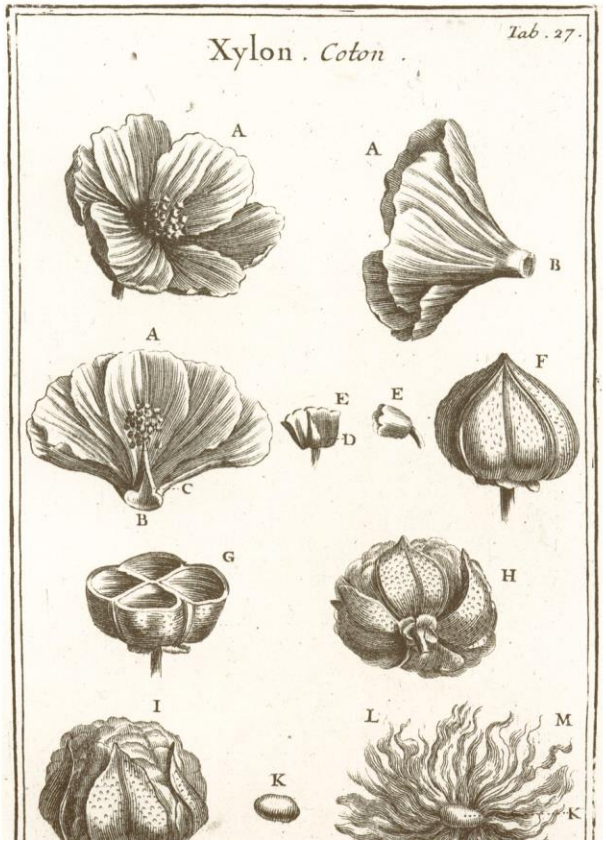
- In what ways do highly evolved and self-aware beings relate to nature?
- What roles do language, literature, and art play in this relation?
- How have modernization and globalization processes transformed nature?
- Is it possible to return to more ecologically attuned ways of inhabiting nature, and what would be the cultural prerequisites for such a change?

Ursula Heise, "The Hitchhiker's Guide to Ecocriticism" (504)

Nature = a Social Construct

In the 1990s, under influence of French post-structuralist critics (Foucault, Barthes, etc.) literary critics "took a fresh look at questions of representation, textuality, narrative, identity, subjectivity, and historical discourse from a fundamentally *skeptical* perspective that emphasized the multiple disjunctures between forms of representation and the realities they purported to refer to...the notion of nature tended to be approached as a sociocultural construct" (Heise 505).

How do our Scientific and Aesthetic Approaches Change the Way we See or Conceptualize Nature?



Andy Warhol, Do it Yourself Landscape, 1962

Does an artistic rendition bring one closer to nature or alienate one from it?

Ursula Heise on Ecocriticism

Ursula Heise identifies as eco-criticism's "triple allegiance" to

1. the scientific study of nature
2. the scholarly analysis of cultural representations (*discourse* in word, image, news media, etc.)
3. the political struggle for more sustainable ways of inhabiting the natural world (506).

National Parks

Wilderness or environment as cultural product. Displacement of indigenous communities

A Critique of Modern Society's Priorities

"Environmentalism and ecocriticism aim their critique of modernity at its presumption to know the natural world scientifically, to manipulate it technologically and exploit it economically, and thereby ultimately to create a human sphere apart from it"..."This domination strips nature of any value other than as a material resource and commodity"..."Such domination empties human life of the significance it had derived from living in and with nature and alienates individuals and communities from their rootedness in place" (Heise 507).

GREENWASHING as a Capitalistic Strategy

Social Ecology Follows an Inter-sectional Approach

- Consideration of factors such as gender, race, class, ability, place, etc.
- "Nature" as concept becomes a site of contested meanings.
- Increased focus on urban spaces
- Socially engaged: examines the impact of civic and corporate actions and policies on the environment and society
- Environmental Justice: addresses social inequalities and works for access and protections for all.
- "The Commons:" How are commonly held resources shared and maintained?
- Triple Bottom Line: Companies asked to consider People, Planet, Profit
- Literary examples: Ursula Le Guin, "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas," Cormac McCarthy, *The Road*, Richard Powers, "The Seventh Event."

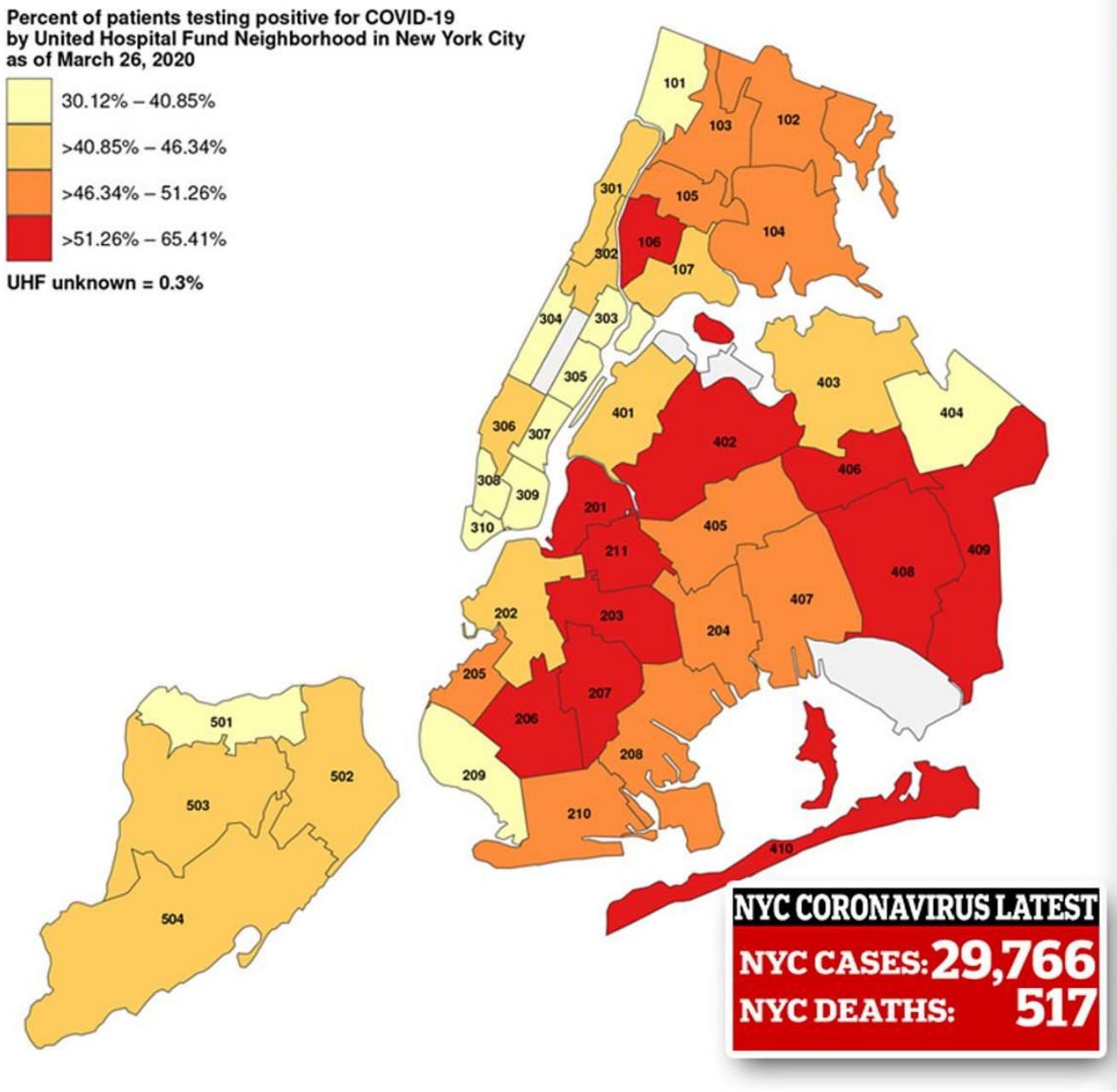
Principles of Environmental Justice (1991)

WE, THE PEOPLE OF COLOR, gathered together at this multinational People of Color Environmental Leadership Summit, to begin to build a national and international movement of all peoples of color to fight the destruction and taking of our lands and communities, do hereby re-establish our spiritual interdependence to the sacredness of our Mother Earth; to respect and celebrate each of our cultures, languages and beliefs about the natural world and our roles in healing ourselves; to ensure environmental justice; to promote economic alternatives which would contribute to the development of environmentally safe livelihoods; and, to secure our political, economic and cultural liberation that has been denied for over 500 years of colonization and oppression, resulting in the poisoning of our communities and land and the genocide of our peoples, do affirm and adopt these Principles of Environmental Justice:

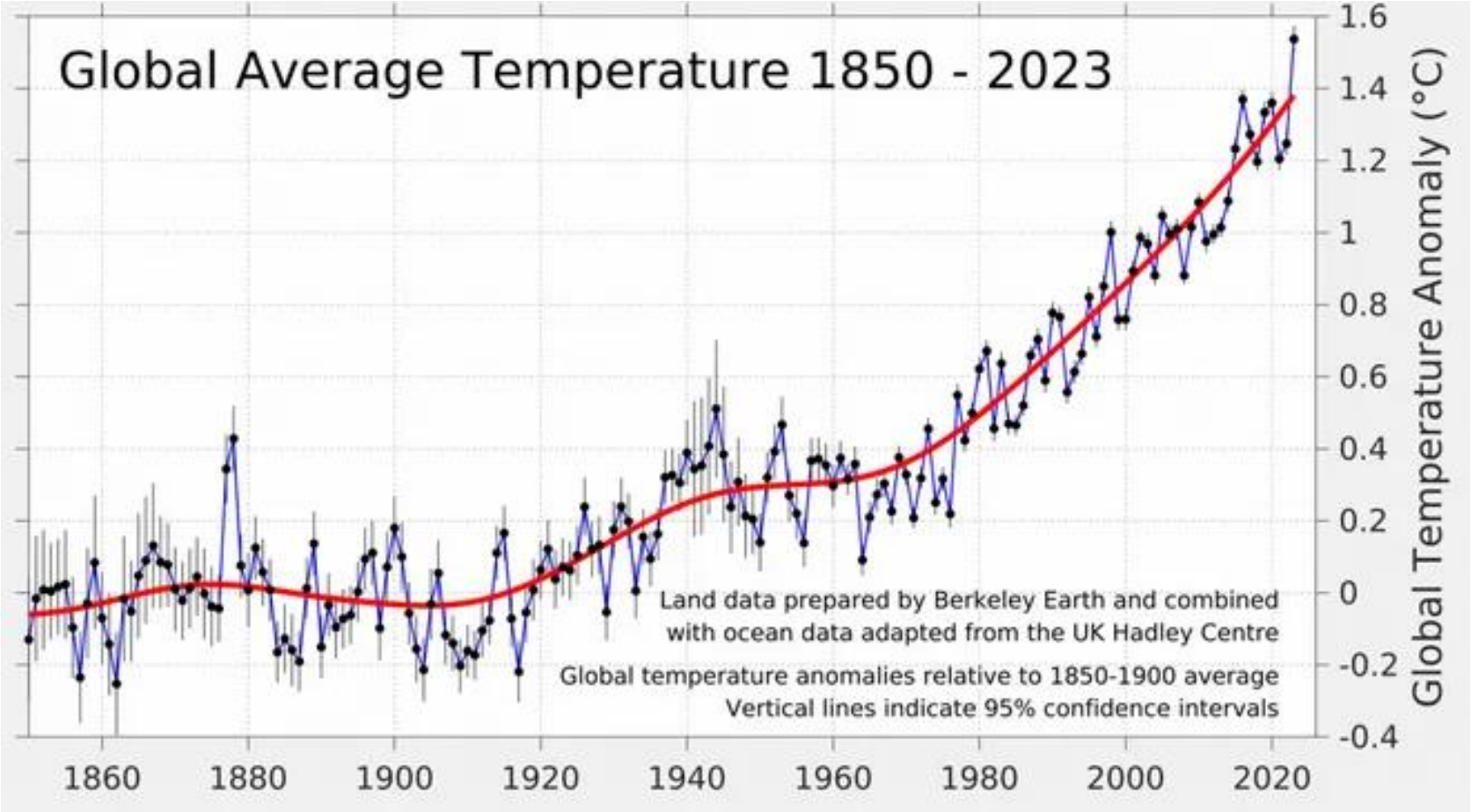
COVID-19 Rates NYC March, 2020

"America is still segregated and so is pollution... today zip code is still the most potent predictor of an individual's health and well-being"

Dr. Robert Bullard



Climate Action & Environmental Crisis



Great Pacific Garbage Patch

Consequences of Intellectualizing

- As Sustainability Studies emerges as an academic discipline, it finds its place in the university institution.
- Ecocriticism becomes a legitimate field of study, including ecofeminism, human ecology & other branches.
- Battle lines are drawn as far as appropriate approaches to climate solutions, equity, science/nature debates.
- Binaries such as human / nature; nature / culture; humans / other animals lead to a "crisis of perception."
- The Rational can be privileged over Feelings / Emotional experience, and this can have a numbing effect.
- We speak in terms of concepts not consciousness (Tiokasin Ghosthorse)
- We may forget to listen with nature, to be *with* earth.

Danez Smith, "Summer Somewhere"

somewhere, a sun. below, boys brown
as rye play the dozens & ball, jump

in the air & stay there. boys become new
moons, gum-dark on all sides, beg bruise

-blue water to fly, at least tide, at least
spit back a father or two. i won't get started.

history is what it is. it knows what it did.
bad dog. bad blood. bad day to be a boy

color of a July well spent. but here, not earth
not heaven, we can't recall our white shirts

turned ruby gowns. here, there's no language
for *officer* or *law*, no color to call *white*.

if snow fell, it'd fall black. please, don't call
us dead, call us alive someplace better.

we say our own names when we pray.
we go out for sweets & come back.

Eco-Anxiety & Search for Solutions

Works Cited

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